

asking your lawyer or broker to send you copies of your property documents, or your HR to send salary details over Gmail, would you? Of course, as naive or simplistic as it may sound, you also always have the option of not using a particular service. The Terms of Service for any online service is available for your viewing at any point of time and if there's something there you don't agree with,

recognizes the right to privacy only of its own citizens, which is the policy that the US government follows.

So, what happens when a company you've chosen to trust with your data gets in bed with a government that you don't?

Unfortunately, the answer to that is, 'nothing good', especially if you live outside the US but primarily use online services from American companies,

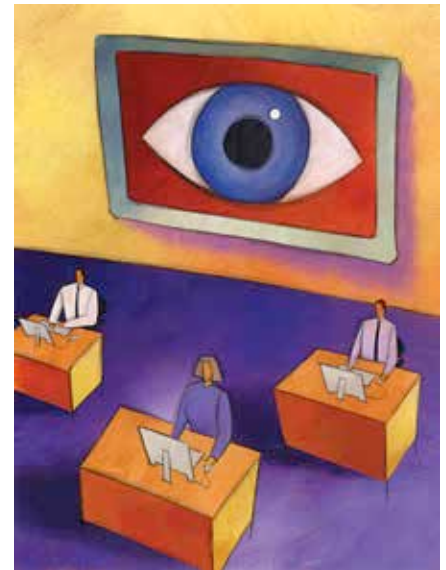
"According to a confidential NSA slideshow presentation, Microsoft began providing data to the PRISM program back in September of 2007."

you can bid adieu to that service. However difficult or complicated the process may be, the truth is that online services do offer you a choice.

Now, with governments, it's a different story altogether. You don't really have a choice whether you want to trust your government or not. While there is implicit trust in play, Snowden's revelations have proved that there is a LOT that governments do that concern you but you're not made aware of. That gets even worse when the government in question is not even of your country and that government follows a formal policy that

something that describes most Internet users in India. Post-the Snowden expose, when the media began reporting that most of the big online companies were sharing user information with the US government wholesale (and getting paid for it), the companies reacted with absolute denials stating that they were only cooperating with the government up to the extent required by specific court orders and warrants. As it turns out, while there's some truth to that, there's also more to the story.

As per the documents leaked by the Guardian, Microsoft may have been the



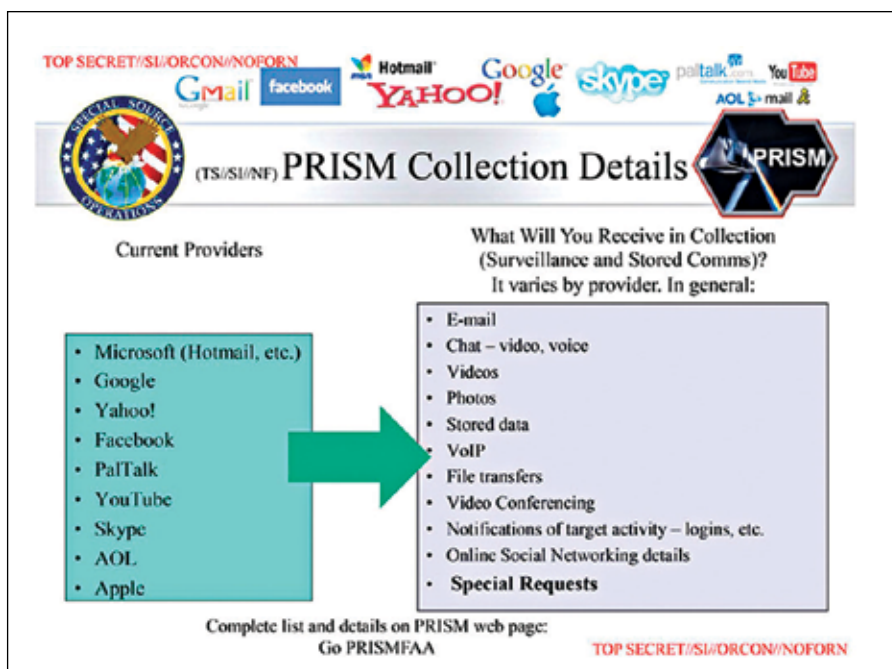
Big brother is watching

first company to agree to a relationship with the NSA. According to a confidential NSA slideshow presentation, Microsoft began providing data to the PRISM program back in September of 2007. Microsoft has also allegedly provided the NSA with a method to access emails and chats on Hotmail and Outlook.com, before they are encrypted.

Microsoft, on its part, has denied that it has a special relationship with the NSA and has stressed that it only shares user information when served with a legal order.

Google's relationship with the NSA (which began in January 2009) has been more tenuous when compared to Microsoft's. While the Snowden documents accuse Google of engaging in similar activities as Microsoft to make it easier for the intelligence agencies to procure user information, Google has also vociferously denied the existence of a back door to its servers and while it has admitted that it has been the subject of numerous requests from the US government with respect to level of access to user data, it has denied permission for any direct access to its hardware. Instead, as told to Wired by Google Spokesperson Chris Gaither, Google responds to data requests backed by a legal order by either handing over the data in person to the agencies involved or through a secure FTP server where the data is hosted for the perusal of the NSA.

Being the largest entity on the Internet, it's only obvious that Google will



A slide from the leaked NSA presentation